

NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA GURUKULAM

Centre for Civilisational Statecraft

CIVILISATIONAL STATECRAFT SERIES | WORKING PAPER VI

A SYSTEMS THEORY OF SOCIAL ORDER

Rethinking Unity, Diversity, and Dharma



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April 2026 | Navi Mumbai

Working Paper — Draft for Circulation

Version 1.0 | April 2026

Comments and feedback are welcome.



Dharmo viśvasya jagataḥ pratiṣṭhā

Dharma is the foundation of the entire universe.

Executive Summary

This paper advances a systems theory of social order grounded in the relationship between unity, diversity, and *dharma*. It traces modern liberalism to a theological insight of unity, later translated into the political principle of human equality. While this secures dignity and rights, it remains structurally incomplete: it does not fully explain how enduring differences in roles and capacities are to be coherently organised.

In response, the paper proposes a *dhārmic* framework that distinguishes three levels: unity at the level of Being, diversity at the level of Becoming expressed as function, and *dharma* as the principle that aligns them. Drawing on systems theory, it argues that stable societies organise difference rather than eliminate it, and that freedom, while secured politically in liberal thought, is in a *dhārmic* framework ontologically grounded and realised through alignment, pointing toward a deeper, internal form of freedom.

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* illustrates this model in practice, showing how differentiated roles can generate a shared experiential unity. The paper affirms equality as a necessary foundation, but argues that a sustainable social order requires institutional and ethical conditions that preserve dignity, enable mobility, and sustain coherence across difference.

Table of Contents

Executive Summary	2
I. From Theological Unity to Political Equality	4
II. The Moral Achievement and Structural Limits of Liberalism	6
III. Dharma and Historical Experience: A Necessary Clarification	7
IV. A Dhārmic Systems Theory	8
V. Reframing Equality: From Sameness to Alignment	11
VI. Nāṭya as a Living Model of Unity in Diversity	13
VII. The Contemporary Limits of Liberal Order	14
VIII. Conditions of a Dhārmic Framework	15
IX. Toward a Theory of Social Order	17

Human societies have long grappled with a persistent question: how can unity be sustained alongside visible and enduring difference? Across civilisations, this tension has shaped moral thought, political organisation, and social structure.

I. From Theological Unity to Political Equality

The moral architecture of modern liberalism did not arise in isolation. It emerges from a longer civilisational evolution in which theological, philosophical, and political ideas gradually transform across domains and contexts.

One of the deepest strands in this evolution lies in the Christian affirmation of the spiritual unity, expressed in Galatians 3:28: *‘There is neither Jew nor Gentile... slave nor free... male nor female, for you are all one in Christ Jesus.’*¹ This articulation of unity at the level of ultimate Being carried far-reaching ethical implications. It relativised inherited distinctions and introduced the possibility of a more universal moral community.

Over time, this metaphysical intuition underwent a series of historical transformations. The theological claim of equality before God gradually informed emerging political thought, contributing to the development of doctrines of natural rights and equal moral worth.² Thinkers such as Alexis de Tocqueville and G. W. F. Hegel recognised this continuity between religious anthropology and modern political ideals.

Yet this inheritance did not remain within a theological frame. In the wake of prolonged religious conflict in post-Reformation Europe, political thought increasingly sought stability by delinking public order from doctrinal commitment. Religion was relocated to the domain of private belief, while political life came to be organised around more minimal and ostensibly universal principles, such as the right to life, liberty, and security.³

¹ Francis Fukuyama, “What Is Western Civilization?,” *Frankly Fukuyama*, YouTube video, March 5, 2026, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Sq6MWZVBPgY>.

² Ibid.

³ Ibid.

In this process, the moral vocabulary of Christianity was not abandoned so much as translated into secular terms. The language of divine equality became the language of human rights. The unity of souls before God became the equality of individuals before the law. Modern liberalism, in this sense, is a secular crystallisation of a theological inheritance: one that preserves its ethical force while reconstituting its foundations.

Today, however, this moral architecture confronts a moment of visible strain. Across the world, the relationship between unity and diversity, once held together within liberal frameworks, appears increasingly unstable, with growing tensions between economic integration and political fragmentation. At the same time, the global centre of gravity is shifting, and societies beyond the historical West are no longer merely recipients of liberal frameworks but active participants in their reinterpretation and renewal.⁴

Countries such as India, marked by long civilisational experience in organising plurality without collapsing it into uniformity, are positioned not only to inherit but to reshape the normative vocabulary of social order. The question, therefore, is no longer only how equality is affirmed, but how structured difference is to be meaningfully coordinated within a shared social framework. While modern liberal thought has articulated unity with moral clarity, it often encounters difficulty in accommodating difference without slipping into hierarchy or fragmentation.

This paper proposes a *dhārmic* systems framework as an alternative lens through which the relationship between unity, diversity, and social order may be reconsidered. Human order, in this view, may be understood across three interrelated principles: unity at the level of Being, diversity at the level of Becoming expressed as function, and *dharma* as the principle that sustains their alignment.

⁴ Fareed Zakaria, "A New Star Rises: India's Potential and Promise." *OP Jindal Distinguished Lecture*, Watson Institute for International and Public Affairs, Brown University, March 18, 2026. YouTube video, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Zt_tG7wkJ6A.

II. The Moral Achievement and Structural Limits of Liberalism

There is much to affirm in the liberal project. By grounding political order in the equal dignity of individuals, liberalism disrupted entrenched systems of domination and widened the circle of moral concern. Its emphasis on rights, fairness, and individual autonomy remains indispensable to modern public life.

Equality, in this sense, is a necessary achievement. It establishes a non-negotiable moral floor: equal protection, equal dignity, and equal access to opportunity.

Liberalism's durability lies not only in its moral clarity, but also in its institutional innovations, including constitutional governance, rule of law, and rights-based protections, which have demonstrably expanded human freedom across societies. These are not incidental achievements, but enduring contributions to human political organisation.

While liberalism secures the individual against domination, it offers a procedurally minimal account of how differentiated roles, identities, and social functions are to be meaningfully integrated into a functional whole. Institutions can distribute power. They cannot determine the ends that power serves.

At the same time, its philosophical structure reveals a subtle tension. The Christian intuition of oneness speaks to a unity at the level of ultimate Being. It is metaphysical in scope. When translated into a political doctrine, however, it becomes a principle governing social arrangements.

Liberalism translates a metaphysical intuition of unity into a political principle of equality. In doing so, it preserves the ethical impulse but collapses the distinction between levels of reality. Unity at the level of Being is reframed as equality at the level of institutions. In this move, ontological and social levels are brought into alignment, but not analytically distinguished.

This translation has been historically productive, but conceptually incomplete. Liberalism successfully translates metaphysical unity into moral equality, but lacks a corresponding account of how differentiated social functions are to be coherently organised. It assumes that a truth about ultimate reality can directly govern social organisation. Yet human life is irreducibly diverse, marked by differences of role, disposition, capacity, and context. Institutional design can regulate interaction, but it cannot by itself generate the ethical motivations on which its stability depends.

A *dhārmic* systems view does not reject equality. It recognises it as a necessary corrective to injustice, but not as a complete account of social order.

The question that follows is foundational: does the translation from spiritual unity to political equality preserve the structure of the original insight, or does it transform it in significant ways?

III. Dharma and Historical Experience: A Necessary Clarification

Any articulation of a *dhārmic* framework must confront a serious and legitimate concern. Historically, structures justified in the name of *dharma* have, at times, hardened into systems of hierarchy, exclusion, and inherited disadvantage. For many, especially those associated with communities such as the *śūdra*, the language of order and differentiation evokes not harmony, but denial of dignity and opportunity.

Over time, what began as differentiation of roles became restriction of access. Interpretations of *dharma*, instead of regulating power, were at times invoked to justify its consolidation. These distortions were not incidental. They became institutionalised across centuries, shaping access to knowledge, labour, and dignity. Any contemporary articulation of *dharma* must therefore be accountable not only to principle, but also to historical consequence.

A Dhārmic Systems Theory, as articulated here, does not defend such outcomes. It draws a clear distinction between *dharma* as a principle of alignment and

social arrangements that have deviated from that principle. When differentiation becomes rigid, and disconnected from lived capacity or context, it ceases to be *dhārmic*. It becomes a form of disorder masquerading as order.

If unity is truly ontological, then dignity cannot be conditional. It cannot depend on role, status, or social function. A *dhārmic* view grounds dignity at a level deeper than political equality. It holds that essential Being is non-differentiated. Any system that denies this in practice stands in contradiction to its own foundation.

Traditional categories such as *varṇa* may be read, in their idealised form, as attempts to describe functional diversity within a larger whole. In a *dhārmic* systems view, such differentiation must remain dynamic, contextual, and reversible. Any system that restricts mobility, or denies capacity for transformation, becomes pathological.

The validity of such a framework cannot rest on philosophical coherence alone. It must be demonstrated through institutions that expand dignity, preserve mobility, and prevent concentration of power.

Such a framework must take institutional form. It would require mechanisms that ensure mobility across roles, prevent concentration of power, and align function with demonstrated capacity. Without such safeguards, the language of *dharma* risks being appropriated by the very distortions it seeks to correct.

The distance between principle and practice is therefore not unique to any one civilisation. Just as liberal equality has coexisted with exclusion in its historical unfolding, so too *dhārmic* categories have, at times, diverged from their normative intent.

IV. A Dhārmic Systems Theory

A Dhārmic Systems Theory is not merely a philosophical construct. It finds resonance across domains of contemporary knowledge. The term *dharma*

derives from the Sanskrit root *dhr* ('to sustain' or 'to uphold'), often expressed in the formulation *dhārayati iti dharmah*, that which sustains.

Across scientific disciplines, from biology to complex systems theory, a converging insight has emerged: complexity does not sustain itself without constraint and organisation.⁵⁶ If human societies are complex systems, the same structural logic applies.

Biological systems offer a clear illustration. At every level, differentiated components perform distinct functions. Their coordination is essential. Integration ensures coherence, while feedback mechanisms maintain stability over time.

A similar insight is articulated within the *dhārmic* tradition through analogies drawn from biological organisation. Just as differentiated cells and organs perform distinct functions while contributing to the integrity of the whole, social order is sustained not by uniformity, but by the coordination of diverse roles within an overarching structure of alignment.⁷

In systems terms, liberal equality functions as a constraint against domination, but not as a principle of organisation. It prevents breakdown, but does not by itself generate coherence. A viable social order requires not only protection of individuals, but the structuring of relationships.

Classical Indian thought described the patterned order of reality as *ṛta*⁸, and its expression in human life as *dharma*.⁹ What modern systems theory describes as stability through constraint, the *dhārmic* tradition understands as order sustained through alignment. *Dharma* may be understood as the principle that refines and organises group living, much as biological systems coordinate

⁵ Scott E. Page, "*Diversity and Complexity*" (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2011).

⁶ Ludwig von Bertalanffy, *General System Theory: Foundations, Development, Applications* (New York: George Braziller, 1968).

⁷ Sudha Seshayyan, "Organisational Dharma of Human Society," *Tattvāloka Onward March to Rāma Rājya Distinguished Lecture*, June 26, 2018, YouTube video playlist, <https://youtube.com/playlist?list=PLs8LRdUXZsHmC100C6ou7ZuzzGL-QQCSz>.

⁸ *Ṛta* refers to the underlying cosmic order in Vedic thought, of which *dharma* is the normative expression in human life.

⁹ Raimon Panikkar, "*The Vedic Experience: Mantramañjarī*" (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1977).

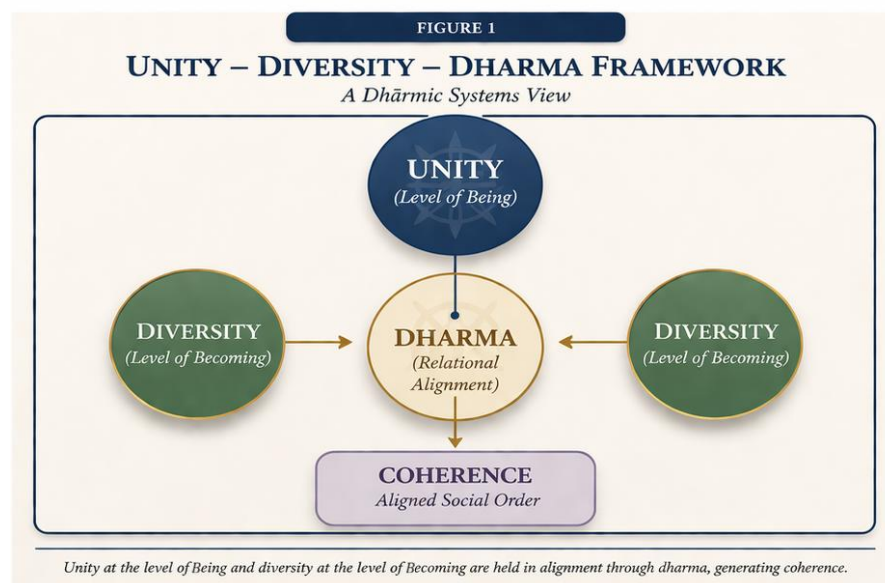
differentiated units into a coherent and functioning whole.¹⁰ The parallel is structural, not metaphorical.

The *dhārmic* perspective begins from a different premise. Human existence is a layered system, in which different levels of reality operate according to different principles. This distinction may also be expressed as the difference between Being and Becoming. Unity belongs to the level of Being: underlying, unchanging, and universal. Diversity belongs to the level of Becoming: dynamic, contextual, and expressed through time. *Dharma* is the principle that maintains coherence between the two, ensuring that the movement of Becoming does not lose alignment with the ground of Being. *Dharma* operates not only as a structural principle of alignment, but also as an internalised source of orientation, shaping how individuals understand and exercise their roles within a shared order.

At the metaphysical level, reality is unified; at the practical level, life unfolds as diversity.

This may be articulated as the Dhārmic Systems Theory:

- Unity is ontological
- Diversity is functional
- *Dharma* is relational



¹⁰ Seshayyan, “Organisational Dharma of Human Society.”

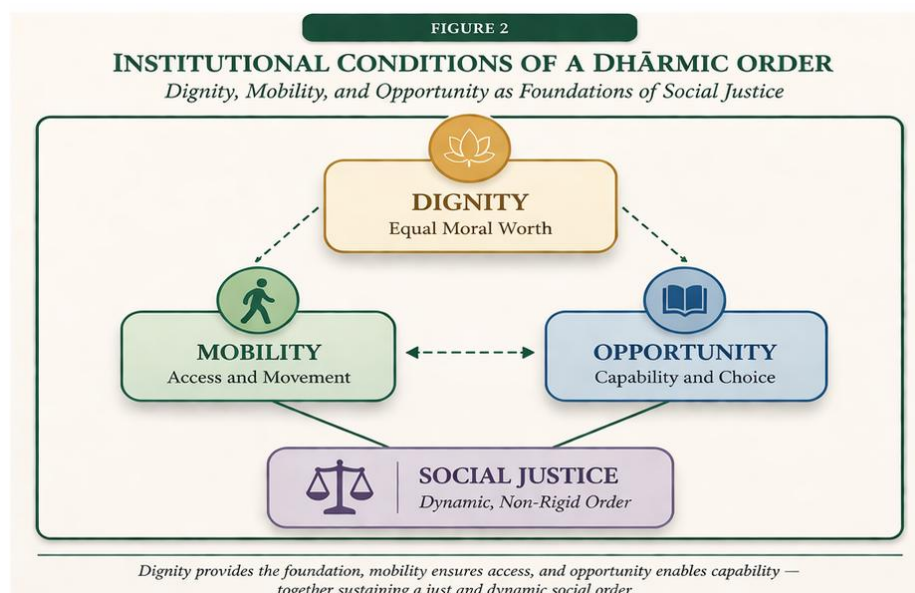
If *dharma* sustains the alignment between unity and diversity at the level of structure, it also orders the relationship between power and desire at the level of motivation.

The task of a stable civilisation is not to collapse these levels into one another, but to sustain their alignment. A stable social order therefore depends not only on how relationships are structured, but on how human aims are oriented within that structure.

Dharma does not erase difference. It orders it.¹¹ The ethical task is not to enforce sameness, but to ensure coherence across levels.

V. Reframing Equality: From Sameness to Alignment

Any *dhārmic* framework must begin with a non-negotiable floor: equal access to dignity, mobility, and opportunity. Without this, differentiation collapses into domination.



Seen through this lens, the limitation of liberalism becomes clearer. Equality constrains injustice, but it does not specify how differentiated roles, capacities, and institutions are to be meaningfully coordinated.

¹¹ *Bhagavad Gītā* 3.35.

In liberal thought, freedom is primarily understood in political terms, as the protection of the individual from external constraint. It is secured through institutions, rights, and the regulation of power.

In a *dhārmic* framework, freedom has a different grounding. It is not merely political, but ontological, grounded in the nature of Being itself. In this sense, freedom is not something granted by institutions, but something realised through alignment.

The role of *dharma* is therefore not to limit freedom, but to make its expression possible within a world of plurality. Structure does not negate freedom; it enables it. What appears as constraint at the level of action is, at a deeper level, the condition for coherence.

Systems do not become stable by making their components identical. They become stable when differentiated components operate in alignment with shared constraints. From this perspective, equality need not imply sameness of role or function. Rather, it may be understood as the equal indispensability of differentiated contributions within a shared order. Just as in a living system, where smaller and larger organs alike are essential to the functioning of the whole, dignity does not arise from uniformity, but from meaningful participation in a coordinated structure.¹²

Where liberalism seeks to resolve difference through sameness, a systems view suggests that stability emerges from structured diversity. The challenge of social order is not only to constrain behaviour, but to orient motivation. Difference, in this view, is not a marker of hierarchy, but a condition for complementarity.¹³

The breakdown lies not in difference itself, but in its misalignment with underlying unity. The remedy is not the erasure of structure, but its reorientation.

Unity does not culminate in sameness. It is expressed through right relationship.

¹² Seshayyan, "*Organisational Dharma of Human Society*."

¹³ Ibid.

In *dhārmic* thought, this alignment is expressed through the idea of *maryādā*¹⁴, boundary. It is not arbitrary restriction, but enabling structure. It defines the conditions under which freedom can be exercised without destabilising the whole.

VI. Nāṭya as a Living Model of Unity in Diversity

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* offers a concrete and sophisticated illustration of this framework. In dramatic performance, difference is foundational. Characters vary in status, temperament, and circumstance. A king, a servant, a lover, and an ascetic each inhabit distinct roles. These distinctions are not erased or equalised.

Yet through *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa*¹⁵, their emotional worlds become universally accessible. The spectator does not become the character. Nor are all characters rendered the same. Instead, one participates in their experience.

What emerges is coherence of experience without equality of roles. This coherence is not merely psychological. Classical aesthetic theory, particularly in the work of Abhinavagupta, the celebrated commentator of *Nāṭyaśāstra*, suggests that *rasa*¹⁶ culminates in a shared experiential ground.¹⁷ The spectator participates in emotion without personal attachment, and what remains is a distilled, impersonal enjoyment.

In this sense, aesthetic experience points toward an underlying unity of consciousness, not asserted conceptually, but encountered directly. The stage thus becomes not only a site of representation, but a field in which difference resolves into a shared experiential ground. While articulated with particular clarity in the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, analogous processes of shared aesthetic participation may be observed across dramatic traditions.

¹⁴ *Maryādā* denotes boundary or limit understood not as restriction, but as an enabling condition for order and right relation.

¹⁵ *Sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* refers to the process by which individual emotions are universalised and made accessible to the spectator.

¹⁶ *Rasa* denotes the aesthetic essence or distilled emotional experience relished by the spectator.

¹⁷ Abhinavagupta, *Abhinavabhāratī*, in “*Nāṭyaśāstra of Bharata*,” trans. Manomohan Ghosh (Calcutta: Asiatic Society, 1951–1961); see also Gnoli, Raniero, “*The Aesthetic Experience According to Abhinavagupta*” (Rome: Istituto Italiano per il Medio ed Estremo Oriente, 1956)

The performance integrates diverse elements into a unified experiential field. Difference is preserved, yet it no longer obstructs connection. It becomes the medium through which connection is realised. In this process, the spectator is not merely informed, but effectively aligned. One enters into the experience of another without the erasure of difference. What is generated is not sameness, but empathy.

Crucially, no character is denied emotional depth or experiential significance on account of status. The king and the commoner are equally capable of evoking *rasa*. The aesthetic field does not erase difference. It refuses to assign lesser interiority to any role.

Nāṭya thus embodies the *dhārmic* systems view in practice. It demonstrates that unity can be lived without erasing diversity, and that universality need not depend on sameness.

In Shakespearean drama too, for instance, characters occupy sharply differentiated roles. Kings, heroes, heroines, aides, friends, and fools each occupy distinct roles within the dramatic structure. Similarly, in Western ballet and musical theatre, distinct roles are preserved, but unified through choreography, narrative, and shared aesthetic experience.

What these traditions suggest is that coherence does not arise from flattening difference, but from structuring it within a shared expressive field.

The significance of this model extends beyond the aesthetic domain. What *Nāṭya* demonstrates in experiential form is a more general principle of social organisation: that coherence can arise not through the erasure of difference, but through its structured alignment. The question that follows is whether such a principle can inform the organisation of social and political life at a broader scale.

VII. The Contemporary Limits of Liberal Order

When extended to the level of contemporary societies, this question acquires renewed urgency. A central concern in contemporary political thought is the

long-term sustainability of liberal societies. Questions of social trust, recognition, and shared meaning point to a gap between formal equality and lived cohesion. Here, the limits of an equality-centered framework become visible. Legal equality does not by itself generate shared meaning or social cohesion. This tension is not solely conceptual. Liberalism represents a profound normative achievement in grounding equality at the level of moral worth. Its limitations arise not from this insight, but from the difficulty of translating it into stable and coherent social forms.

Societies organised solely around rights often experience fragmentation and a thinning of common life.¹⁸

The growing global interest in contemplative and aesthetic traditions suggests a search for something deeper. These traditions cultivate perception, enabling individuals to experience interconnectedness without erasing difference.

What is being sought is not merely fairness, but coherence. Any such reorientation, however, must remain accountable to both historical experience and contemporary ethical standards.

VIII. Conditions for a Dhārmic Framework

For a *dhārmic* systems framework to be normatively and practically viable, it must rest on a non-negotiable moral foundation: equal dignity, mobility, and access to opportunity. Unity at the level of Being cannot coexist with institutional arrangements that condition dignity on status or function. Any differentiation of roles must therefore operate within a framework that guarantees the possibility of movement, participation, and recognition across the social order.

Any viable framework of social order must satisfy not only conceptual coherence, but also an experiential test. It must be lived as fair, intelligible, and dignity-affirming by those within it. Where the language of order obscures asymmetry or restricts mobility, it ceases to be *dhārmic* in practice, regardless of its formal justification. The legitimacy of such a system therefore depends not only on its structure, but on its lived intelligibility.

¹⁸ Robert D. Putnam, *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2000)

At the institutional level, a *dhārmic* order requires safeguards that prevent the rigidification of roles and the concentration of power. Functional differentiation must remain dynamic, aligned with demonstrated capacity and contextual need. Such conditions cannot be sustained by institutional design alone. They depend on the ethical orientation of individuals, through which the exercise of power and the pursuit of interest remain aligned with a broader order.

Such a framework must also preserve the possibility of movement across roles. Differentiation that becomes fixed ceases to reflect alignment and instead hardens into constraint. A *dhārmic* order therefore requires conditions under which individuals may develop, adapt, and assume different functions in accordance with capacity and context.¹⁹ Mechanisms that enable periodic reassessment, open access to knowledge, and distributed authority are essential to ensure that structure does not harden into hierarchy. Without such correctives, differentiation risks becoming exclusionary, undermining the very coherence it seeks to sustain.

Finally, the stability of such a system depends on the continuous alignment between unity and diversity. *Dharma*, in this sense, is a regulating principle that must be interpreted and applied in changing circumstances. Institutions must therefore be capable of reflexivity, adapting to shifts in social complexity while maintaining coherence across levels. A *dhārmic* social order is thus not defined by static arrangements, but by its capacity to sustain alignment between underlying unity and lived diversity over time.

A parallel insight may be observed in modern constitutional experience. The Constitution of independent India initially articulated a comprehensive framework of fundamental rights, while duties were incorporated only later. This evolution reflects a broader recognition that rights alone are insufficient to sustain social order without corresponding responsibility.

This concern was anticipated by Mahatma Gandhi, who cautioned against excessive reliance on legal and institutional mechanisms, emphasising instead the ethical responsibility of individuals. Institutions may structure behaviour, but they cannot substitute for the cultivation of right conduct. A stable social order therefore depends not only on formal guarantees, but on the internalisation of responsibility by those who inhabit it.

¹⁹ Seshayyan, “*Organisational Dharma of Human Society*.”

IX. Toward a Theory of Social Order

The recognition of an underlying human unity remains one of the most powerful civilisational insights of the modern world. Yet its fullest expression does not lie in its translation into equality alone.

A Dhārmic Systems Theory offers a deeper account: unity belongs to the level of Being, diversity to the level of Becoming, and *dharma* to the principle that sustains their relationship.

Any invocation of *dharma* that justifies exclusion or denies dignity marks a departure from the tradition.

We are not equal because we are the same. We are equal because our Being is shared, even as our functions differ.

Equality is the floor of justice. *Dharma* is the architecture that makes civilisation livable. The durability of such an order depends not only on the coherence of its structure, but on the orientation of the ends that its structure serves.

The challenge before contemporary thought may not be simply to defend equality, but to situate it within deeper frameworks through which unity and diversity can be held in enduring balance.

If liberalism clarified the moral floor of human dignity, a *dhārmic* systems perspective raises a further question: how is a shared world to be meaningfully structured once that dignity is secured?

The question is not whether unity or diversity should prevail, but how their relationship is to be structured.

The task, then, is not merely to secure justice, but to sustain order.
